even invite Zia-ul-Haq for a meeting with me. Maybe we should even "pay" him with something. In short, we need flexibility and quick reaction, otherwise, there will be bloodshed and civil war, and Najibullah will be removed quickly', ordered Gorbachev.[106] The US had detailed intelligence of Soviet decision-making, and so did the PDPA, which was getting increasingly nervous about Soviet courting of Pakistan.[107] Nearly two decades later, when the US began planning its withdrawal from Afghanistan, India again counseled caution in the light of Taliban's resurgence, but had little impact.

Differences between the Indian and US positions also became acute overtime. Rajiv's response to Reagan in January 1987 made it apparent:

> Our [India's] position in Afghanistan is, as you know, that the country should be allowed to chart an independent, non-aligned course, free from intervention and interference. I reiterated this to General Secretary Gorbachev. I also conveyed to him the gist of what you had written to me. The General Secretary left me with the impression that the Soviet Union would like to withdraw its forces in a realistic time-frame from an Afghanistan which would be non-aligned and not unfriendly to the Soviet Union. I hope that a peaceful resolution will not elude us for long. Quite apart from other factors, an early settlement would be in India's interest.[108]

Rajiv went further to denounce Pakistan's continuing exploitation of the Afghan situation, its demand for American AWACS and the Hawkeye Naval Aircraft, and a robust nuclear arms programme that would trigger a qualitative new phase in the arms race in South Asia and enhance tensions to dangerous levels. Reagan's response to Rajiv in March 1987 was cut and dried—a non-aligned coalition government including communist leader Najibullah, as favoured by India, was not acceptable. As put by Dean himself, differences between official US and Indian policies persisted on Afghanistan and nuclear issues. 'Covertly, we [US] supported the Islamic fundamentalist Gulbuddin Hekmatyar who received the lion share of the arms and funds provided to the Afghan resistance. He was at that time "America's man"', claimed Dean.[109] In a secret national security directive on Afghanistan prepared by the White House on 1 May 1987, the Reagan administration was categorical that Moscow's decision to reduce its withdrawal timeline to eighteen months instead of four years was 'designed to persuade the world that Moscow is serious in searching for a solution in Afghanistan, yet clearly aimed to allow Soviet military operations against resistance with decreased external support'.[110] There was more